

Emberwatch — Playtest Questionnaire

Phase 0 validation. Goal: answer the three questions the code cannot — is the core fun, will people engage with monetization, does it retain past run 3. Honest beats kind: a brutal sheet is worth more than a polite one.

Before you start (facilitator fills in)

Build / link tested:

Date:

Tester initials:

Platform:

☐ Phone ☐ Desktop

Device / browser:

Opened via:

☐ Hosted link (http/https) ☐ Other

Must be http(s) in a real browser — not a file opened directly (iOS previews don't run scripts).

VERSION A — OUTSIDE TESTER

For someone who has never seen the game. Do NOT explain anything first. Hand over the link, say "play until you feel done," and watch quietly. Play at least 3 full runs (a run = until you die).

First impressions — the onboarding gate

1. In your own words, what is the goal of this game?

2. Did the opening tutorial appear?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Didn't notice

3. Was it clear?

☐ Totally ☐ Mostly ☐ Confusing ☐ I skipped it

4. What is the campfire for? (from memory)

5. What happens if you go too far from the fire at night?

6. Any moment in your first 3 minutes where you felt lost, stuck, or unsure? Describe it.

7. Did anything make you want to quit before the first run ended?

☐ No ☐ Yes (note below)

If yes — what?

The core loop — combat (Q1: is the core 30 seconds fun?)

8. How fun was the moment-to-moment fighting? (1 = boring, 5 = great)

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

9. Did attacking feel satisfying — did hits land with weight?

☐ Yes ☐ Somewhat ☐ No

10. Class played most:

☐ Ranger ☐ Mage ☐ Knight

Did it feel good to play?

11. Difficulty was:

☐ Too easy ☐ About right ☐ Too hard ☐ Swung wildly

The gather-and-bank loop — the make-or-break mechanic

12. Carrying remains back to the fire felt:

☐ Tense & rewarding ☐ Fine ☐ Tedious / a chore ☐ Didn't realize I had to

13. Did the trip back ever create a "do I risk it?" moment?

☐ Often ☐ Sometimes ☐ Never

14. Did you ever lose remains by dying on the way back?

☐ Yes ☐ No

If yes — how did that feel?

Night & exposure — recently changed, watch closely

15. The dark draining your health at night felt:

☐ Fair & tense ☐ Too punishing ☐ Barely noticed ☐ Killed me before I understood

16. Did you understand WHY you were dying when it happened?

☐ Always ☐ Sometimes ☐ No

Retention (Q3: does it hold past run 3?)

17. After your first run, how much did you want to play again?

☐ Eagerly ☐ Sure ☐ Meh ☐ Not really

18. How many runs did you actually play?

19. By run 3 you were:

☐ More into it ☐ About the same ☐ Losing interest ☐ Already bored

20. What made you want to keep going?

21. What made you want to stop?

22. Would you come back tomorrow to play more?

☐ Definitely ☐ Maybe ☐ Probably not

Monetization (Q2: willingness — honest, nothing is charged)

23. Did you notice "Watch ad +30 embers" on the death screen?

☐ Yes ☐ No

24. Would you watch a short ad for embers / a revive?

☐ Yes, gladly ☐ Sometimes ☐ Never

25. Did you see the "Supporter Pack" option?

☐ Yes ☐ No

26. If polished and free, would you pay ~\$5 once for the Supporter Pack?

☐ Yes ☐ Maybe ☐ No

27. What would make a one-time purchase feel worth it to you?

Feel & polish

28. How did it run on your device?

☐ Smooth ☐ Occasional hitches ☐ Laggy

29. (Phone) Were the controls (joystick, ability buttons) comfortable & responsive?

☐ Yes ☐ Awkward (note below)

If awkward — how?

30. (Phone) Did any button or menu fail to respond to taps?

☐ No ☐ Yes (which?)

If yes — which?

31. Did anything look broken, overlap, or get cut off?

☐ No ☐ Yes (describe / screenshot)

Describe:

Closing

32. One word for how the game made you feel:

33. The single best thing about it:

34. The single worst thing about it:

35. If you could change one thing, what would it be?

VERSION B — SELF-TEST (DEVELOPER)

For you. Verify systems actually fire and catch defects the testers can't. Run on BOTH phone and desktop.

Functional checklist — does it actually work

- ☐ Loads over https; title + all menu buttons respond (incl. iPhone Safari)
- ☐ Tutorial appears on a first-ever run, is tappable, skippable, doesn't reappear next run
- ☐ Each class (Ranger/Mage/Knight) playable; all four abilities (Q/W/E/R) cast
- ☐ Remains collect within magnet range and bank on the fire
- ☐ Level-up screen appears, offers 3 cards, chosen boon applies
- ☐ Fire level grows the light radius on level-up
- ☐ Day/night transition occurs; exposure damage triggers beyond the light at night
- ☐ Exposure rate climbs (1->5) and caps; hurt feedback fires while draining
- ☐ Death screen shows; Revive works and escalates; Restart and Home work
- ☐ Watch-ad grants embers; Supporter Pack opens, 'purchases', removes ads, persists across reload
- ☐ Inventory opens; equipping changes stats; level badge renders top-right
- ☐ No console errors during a full run (desktop dev tools)

Telemetry sanity — set `Telemetry.cfg.endpoint` to a test sink, or watch the network tab

- ☐ `session_start` fires once at first run of the session
- ☐ `run_start` fires with the class
- ☐ `first_bank` fires on first deposit (with time-to-first-bank)
- ☐ `night_start` / `night_survived` fire at phase transitions
- ☐ `level_up` fires with the boon chosen
- ☐ `ad_offered` / `ad_completed` fire around the watch-ad button
- ☐ `supporter_pack_viewed` / `purchased` fire around the modal
- ☐ `run_end` fires with the full run summary
- ☐ With NO endpoint set, nothing breaks (silent-degrade)

Balance read — your judgment

Enemy windups — too kiteable, or fair?

Boss cadence (wave 8, then every 6) — too soon / too rare?

Exposure lethality after the rework — fair tension or cheap deaths?

Death-spill (lose 50% of un-banked carry) — does it sting right?

Ember earn vs revive cost — earned, or stingy/generous?

First three minutes — does run 1 hook without killing the newcomer?

Cross-platform

- ☐ Full run on phone — controls, layout, performance acceptable
- ☐ Full run on desktop — input, layout, performance acceptable

Phone models tested (HUD overlap check):

FACILITATOR — READING THE RESULTS

The three gate questions, and the answers that mean "advance":

Q1 — combat fun: Version A #8 averaging 4+, #9 mostly "Yes." If combat scores low, nothing downstream matters — fix feel first.

Q3 — retention: #18 trending 3+, #19 "more into it / same," #22 "definitely / maybe." The hardest and most important signal.

Q2 — willingness: #24 and #26 — any non-trivial yes/maybe is encouraging for an unpolished prototype; near-zero on both is a flag. (Self-reported intent overstates real behavior — the true Q2 signal is live telemetry later, not this sheet.)

Make-or-break unknown: #12–14 (gather-and-bank — tension or tedium?). If "tedious / a chore" dominates, the central mechanic needs rethinking before any portal spend.

Collect a handful of Version A sheets before concluding — one tester is an anecdote, not a signal.